

Chapter 112-3

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Gu Xingyue couldn't stay here for too long. After talking with Liang Shi, she had to hurry back to school.

She didn't have a driver's license, nor did she have a car. Normally, a driver would pick her up and drop her off for work. In situations like this, Yang Jiani would keep her under strict control, so she would be picked up and dropped off for work.

But this was only for a period of time.

Once she became docile and turned back into Qi Jiao again, putting away her fangs, Yang Jiani would return some of her freedom.

After leaving the tea house, Liang Shi offered to drive her back to the kindergarten, but Gu Xingyue refused.

Gu Xingyue took a taxi and left. Liang Shi stood in place for a while, processing her emotions alone.

Compared to Gu Xingyue, everything she had experienced seemed like nothing.

Liang Shi felt melancholic. It was only after getting back into the car that she took out Qi Jiao's diary.

Gu Xingyue was a very meticulous person. When transcribing Qi Jiao's diary, she first copied it out in Morse code, with the translation on the back.

This made it convenient for Liang Shi to read.

Gu Xingyue had probably almost memorized this diary by now. Most of the content in the diary was about daily life.

Qi Jiao didn't have any friends at school, and she didn't dare make friends with anyone.

But actually, her appearance was the type that people liked—the girl-next-door look, pure and cute. She should have been liked by many people at school.

Yet because of her strange quietness, everyone was afraid to talk to her.

Qi Jiao even got a new desk mate in middle school. After sitting together for a week, her desk mate finally said in surprise, "So you're not a mute after all."

How laughable.

Qi Jiao's ability to express herself began to deteriorate rapidly. She often wanted to communicate with people but didn't know what to say. When facing strangers, she would become unusually nervous, stammering for a long time without being able to get a single sentence out, her face flushing red with embarrassment, not knowing what to do.

So her classmates all thought she had social anxiety.

But actually she didn't. She really wanted to blend in with everyone.

But Yang Jiani didn't like that.

Yang Jiani hated Qi Jiao having any social circle whatsoever. She wished Qi Jiao would only revolve around her alone.

Qi Jiao's life belonged to Yang Jiani.

Qi Jiao also asked in her diary: 【Why can my life only have Mom in it, but Mom's life can have so many people?】

Qi Jiao's diary rarely mentioned Qi Xiangui¹, only a few brief strokes.

To her, the image of her father was very thin. He was a philistine, face-obsessed, extremely selfish businessman. He didn't have just her mother as a woman—Qi Jiao even saw him with another woman on their family sofa when she was twelve.

All the servants in the house knew that her father was cheating. Once she even heard the servants discussing it, saying that men with money all turn bad. So what if the madam's family used to be illustrious? There were plenty of families that were still illustrious now where the men still sought food outside². What's more, Yang Jiani's family was only illustrious in the past—now she was nothing but a fallen wealthy daughter.

Qi Jiao had also asked Yang Jiani why she didn't divorce him, why she didn't take her and leave.

In her innocence, Qi Jiao had once hoped that Yang Jiani would leave Qi Xiangui. That way, Yang Jiani would slowly return to normal.

But Yang Jiani looked at her with a cold smile and asked her back—where would they go? How would they live?

Qi Jiao had also heard Yang Jiani say that in this lifetime, she and Qi Xiangui would fight to the death³.

Qi Jiao wrote in her diary: 【It's very strange. "Fight to the death" should be a phrase used between enemies, but when Mother uses it on Father, I don't find it out of place. They only appear loving in front of cameras, in other people's eyes. I don't know—is everyone's life like this?】

【They wear the skin of hypocrisy and blend into the crowd. No one knows they're just a pack of beasts.】

【I seem to be just a tool, used to obtain emotional value and emotional needs, to become something to compete over and show off. I'm not supposed to have my own thoughts. If that's the case, why not just buy a doll? Or make a marionette—they don't have thoughts.】

【My soul was killed on this night. I'm willing to give up all of this. All these thoughts are meaningless. Life itself is a paradox. We study the origin of the universe, biological evolution, the theory of innate goodness versus innate evil⁴. But I think the things in textbooks are not enough to explain the complex species that is humanity.】

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It was hard not to feel sad after reading Qi Jiao's diary.

Especially since Liang Shi had met her, remembered her, and had many memories with her that weren't beautiful, but where only she was shining.

They had once promised to become kindergarten teachers together, to see the ocean together, to keep each other warm in the darkness, to be each other's source of light.

But unexpectedly, not a single one of their promises was fulfilled.

In what wasn't a very long time, she had forgotten Qi Jiao and missed the remainder of her brief life.

After finishing Qi Jiao's diary, Liang Shi put it in a hidden place before taking out her phone.

It was still on the chat page with Xu Qingzhu that she hadn't closed.

Yang Shuyan's personalized autograph was still hanging in the most prominent place.

Liang Shi typed on the screen: 【I just went to see Gu Xingyue, didn't check my phone.】

She explained why she hadn't replied to messages, then sent another: 【How did you get the autograph so quickly? I wanted to help with that.】

It happened to be Xu Qingzhu's break time, so she replied quickly: 【I happened to be signing a supplementary contract with Yang Shuyan today, so I got it.】

Liang Shi:

As expected of a capitalist.

Liang Shi: 【Alright then.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【Why do I feel like you're unhappy?】

Liang Shi: 【No.】

After a moment, Liang Shi added: 【I'm unhappy because I met with Gu Xingyue. I got Qi Jiao's complete diary.】

Xu Qingzhu's name changed to "the other party is typing," probably organizing her words.

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu sent a ten-second voice message.

That cool, clear voice spoke unhurriedly: "Her diary must be very sad to read. So, Teacher Liang, have you eaten? I'm a bit hungry. If you're not busy... um... could you come keep me company for a meal?"

When Xu Qingzhu spoke, there was no flirtatiousness at all. Her voice was much gentler than usual.

Just from her tone alone, Liang Shi's sadness was stirred up.

Xu Qingzhu hadn't comforted her, yet Liang Shi understood.

Originally, this emotion was something she could handle on her own and would digest quickly. But suddenly, someone said this to her.

Liang Shi felt the sad emotions multiply many times over, and she really wanted to find someone to talk to.

She sat there and replied: 【What a coincidence, I haven't eaten either. Give me ten minutes.】

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1. Qi Xiangui (齊先貴) is Qi Jiao's father and Yang Jiani's husband. ⇐
 2. "Seeking food outside" (在外邊覓食) is a euphemism for having affairs or seeking romantic/sexual partners outside of marriage. ⇐
 3. "Fight to the death" (不死不休) literally means "won't rest until one is dead," indicating an irreconcilable conflict that will only end when one party dies. ⇐
 4. This refers to classical Chinese philosophical debates between Mencius (who believed human nature is inherently good) and Xunzi (who believed human nature is inherently evil). ⇐